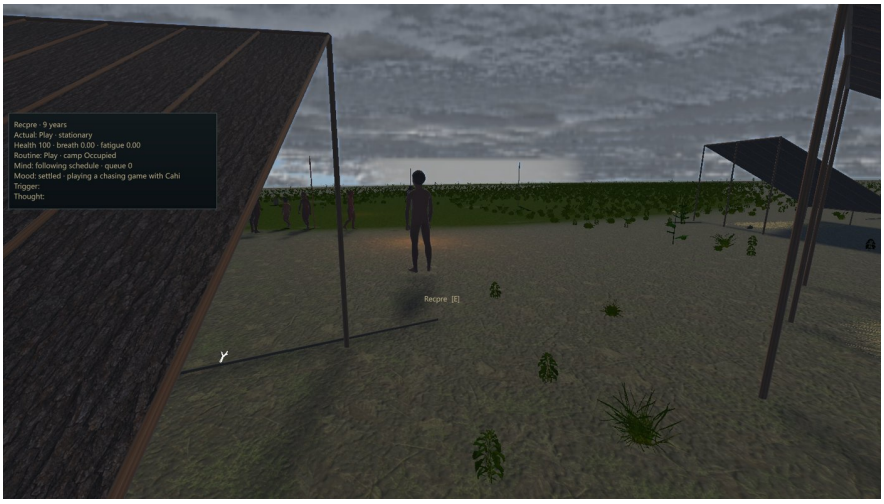
Absence is not an emergency

Expected returns, selective concern and conversations grounded in actual local events.

Situation	What happens
Ordinary outing	Known foraging, water and fuel trips carry an expected return. Adults are generally expected around evening, with a reasonable delay allowed.
Someone overdue	Concern, asking for news, waiting until daylight and searching are separate responses. Relationship, age, risk, duty and personality matter.
Information limits	They know the last observed or reported place, not the absent person's actual location or fate. A rumour alone does not assign a search.
Unobserved interval	Old timestamps do not prove someone missed a check-in while unloaded. A new observation window establishes the next expected return, without inventing a sighting; established concerns and accepted searches remain.
False alarms fixed	Children no longer drift indefinitely while following each other in pretend play. Packing holds also keep residents' schedules at the actual camp.
Conversation	You can join an ongoing exchange, interrupt it and end it without leaving permanent listening holds. Recent contact helps avoid repeated introductions.



Actual controlled play/search test in the packaged game. Actor placement is controlled for the checks; the subsequent ten-second movement uses normal updates.

Speech uses evidence

Successful physical actions now leave bounded records: receiving an item, gathering, delivering, building, dismantling, eating, drinking and tending fire. A duty or a possession is not proof the action happened. Memories distinguish witnessed events from reports.

Live Qwen check: after receiving a scraper, Nusa says she just received it rather than claiming a completed repair. She names the actual coordinator, then answers a time/weather follow-up from current observations. The full short transcript is preserved beside this PDF.

Camps keep their real materials

Local continuity while present and while away, without simulating every tribe worldwide.

Change	Behavior
Arrival logistics	Packing follows the travel decision. Ordinary woodland bark/brush/reed shelters remain standing, including frame lashings. Valuable hide coverings can roll together; wood loads require actual lashing.
Work access	Broad roof components are approached from an exposed edge rather than always targeting the centre beneath the roof.
Stable construction crew	A builder fetching wood outside the camp keeps the assignment instead of being replaced each scan. The crew remains bounded and yields to essential duties or danger.
Unobserved work	Returning to a known camp evaluates bounded background catch-up from saved people, actual carried/staged materials and elapsed time. Existing frames are reused; fresh replacements do not inherit old weather exposure.
Finite supplies	Catch-up cannot replace stolen material or invent missing wood. Incomplete shelters may still require residents to gather more real resources.
Scale	This applies only to locally encountered bands. Distant unvisited bands remain deterministic broad projections; there are no global per-person conversations or daily tasks.



Real local Qwen replies and a generated invitation that grants actual guest permission. The debug thoughts overlay is enabled for verification.

Verification

1,439 focused Core checks passed. Packaged checks passed: camp/material continuity and weather 43; daily life/absence 33; social 26; material gathering/crafting 19; live Qwen dialogue 21; natural woodland departure/arrival and controlled hauling full cycle both passed. The 15-minute-day hauling fixture selects transport explicitly; the cold-location fixture lacked a qualifying community and is not presented as evidence.

Practical limits

The local model can still phrase things poorly or infer too much. Travel skips are explicit in the full-cycle checks. Re-use of original materials is verified; this does not establish that every shelter finishes. Advanced hunting, a complete resource economy and species-specific weathering remain future work.

Left standing, not forgotten

Ageing of real NPC shelter components and abandoned-site remains.

Material / setting	Behavior
Frames and bindings	Stay with a woodland structure unless the band intends to transport them. A tent shape alone no longer forces pole hauling.
Coverings	Hide covers remain valuable portable equipment. Ordinary locally sourced forest roofs can stay in place with the shelter.
Weathering	Elapsed calendar time, material, rainfall, temperature, canopy exposure and ground contact accumulate wear. Warm damp sites generally weather faster; frozen or dry sites preserve wood longer.
Gradual loss	Protection and colour change before components fail. Loss of all ground supports brings down the unsupported remainder. Sound fallen materials remain recoverable; rot reduces mass and usability.



Before: cropped from the actual production shelter, fixed review camera. Full frame preserved beside the PDF.



After: same camera, controlled +720 calendar days using the local district climate. Roof panels fail while the remaining frame is retained; this does not simulate two years of NPC activity.

Scope and cost

NPC camps age lazily on load and at coarse local intervals. No distant per-camp daily simulation is added. The service-life parameters are gameplay approximations; species-specific timber durability, detailed storm physics and terrain erosion are not modelled.

Sources: USDA Wood Handbook · Milwaukee Public Museum: shelter construction and portable coverings